

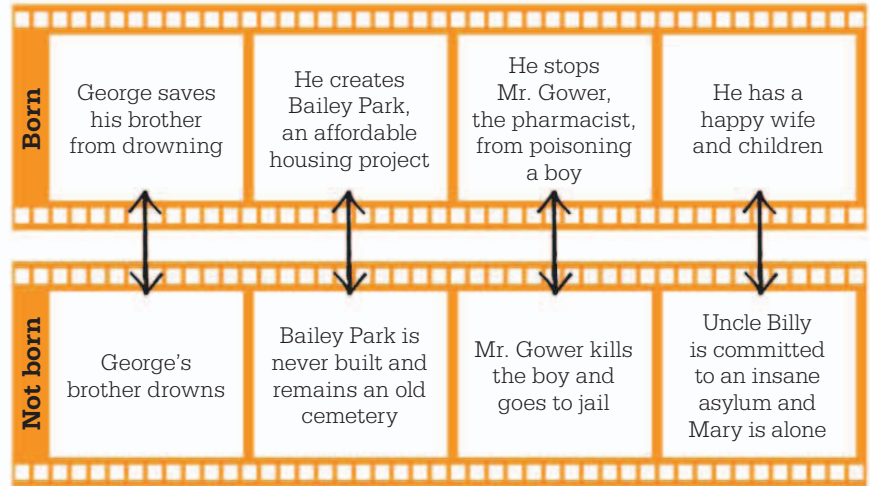
What else to watch: *It Happened One Night* (1934) ■ *You Can't Take It With You* (1938) ■ *Mr. Smith Goes to Washington* (1939) ■ *The Philadelphia Story* (1940) ■ *Harvey* (1950) ■ *Vertigo* (1958, pp.140–45)

the peerless *It Happened One Night* (1934), starring Clark Gable and Claudette Colbert, but he became best known for feel-good movies in which the common man triumphs over cynical corporations or corrupt politicians—themes that resonated strongly with audiences during the Great Depression.

A new mood

Had it been made 10 years earlier, *It's a Wonderful Life* might have been another hit for Capra, but in 1946 he was out of step with the prevailing mood in the US. World War II had robbed the nation's young of any sense of innocence, and audiences no longer had an appetite for pure escapism. Film noir was on the rise, in which morally ambiguous detectives were little better than the criminals they chased.

Yet to the modern eye, *It's a Wonderful Life* seems surprisingly dark, an attempted suicide being the central premise for a story in which a man discovers the true worth of his own life.



After George makes the wish that he had never been born, an angel, Clarence, shows him what would happen if he had never existed

Capra's masterstroke is to begin with a series of whispered prayers for help, heard by heavenly beings who decide to intervene in the life of one George Bailey (James Stewart). They send an angel, but the only one available is Clarence Odbody (Henry Travers) who, at the

tender age of 200, has yet to earn his wings. As Clarence studies George's life in flashback, from boyhood to adulthood, Capra paints a portrait of a loyal townsman who has sacrificed his dreams of travel and career in order to follow in his father's footsteps, helping the local community and working at a small bank in Bedford Falls, New York. »

James Stewart Actor

James Stewart was born in 1908 in Indiana, PA. After a brief stint on Broadway, he followed his old roommate Henry Fonda to Hollywood. His movie career took off in 1938 when Frank Capra cast him in the comedy *You Can't Take It With You*. The following year, the pair made *Mr. Smith Goes to Washington*, which earned Stewart an Oscar nomination. He took time off to join the war effort, but his popularity did not fade, and his first postwar movie, *It's a Wonderful Life*, brought a

third Oscar nomination. The movie epitomized Stewart's quiet, folksy charm, which was again brought to the fore in the 1950 hit *Harvey*. He also made a number of Westerns, and collaborated with Alfred Hitchcock. He died in 1997.

Key movies

1938 *You Can't Take It With You*
1939 *Mr. Smith Goes to Washington*
1946 *It's a Wonderful Life*
1958 *Vertigo*

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I made mistakes in drama. I thought drama was when actors cried. But drama is when the audience cries.

Frank Capra

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